

As you start your recovery

People across the country are being hit with terrible natural disasters from dangerous winter weather to wildfires. Financial services companies, like banks, credit card companies, and other lenders, are expected to help people affected by a major disaster or emergency. This means they should have customer service available to respond to your situation promptly.

[See the CFPB list of actions you can take right away to secure your money and property](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1513) (cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1513)



Start recovering and rebuilding your financial life

After a disaster, your priority is your own safety. Organizations in your community can provide help and services.

You can submit a complaint about a problem with a financial product or service, including problems getting help from a company after a disaster, at consumerfinance.gov/complaint (<https://content.consumerfinance.gov/complaint/>) or by calling [\(855\) 411-CFPB \(2372\)](tel:8554112372).

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Expect help from the companies you use

As you recover from a disaster or emergency, you should contact your lenders and companies where you have accounts, and ask for help. You might ask for:

- Forbearance or adjusted repayment schedules on your loans or debts, along with clear explanations of the help or consideration the lender can offer you
- Facts about how your credit is affected by a forbearance or reduced mortgage payment—for example, the company that handles your mortgage payments can apply a special disaster code on your credit report that explains the situation
- A way to refinance your existing debts, or new loans with terms that are more realistic for you
- Flexibility on paperwork required for loans or payment assistance, if you cannot locate or access documents because of the event
- Reduced or waived fees and charges, like overdraft fees, ATM fees, or late fees
- Increases in the amount you are allowed to withdraw in cash from an ATM

Sometimes a disaster or other event means you need to leave your home, or your telephone or internet service could be interrupted. Set up a forwarding address for your mail and update your contact information, to make sure you receive checks you are expecting, messages about your bills and loans, and other important documents before problems arise.

You can submit a complaint about a problem with a financial product or service, including problems getting help from a company after a disaster, at consumerfinance.gov/complaint or by calling [\(855\) 411-CFPB \(2372\)](tel:855411CFPB).

Take care of your housing situation

Stable housing is usually a top priority for people in areas affected by natural disasters and emergencies. Here are a few considerations that can help you stabilize your situation.

Managing mortgage payments

If you can't pay your mortgage or are worried about missing a payment, call your lender or loan servicer right away. Ask about ways they can make your payments more affordable. These are called “loss mitigation options” and they can include forbearance or loan modifications. Once you get information about your options, you can [go over it with a housing counselor \(https://www.consumerfinance.gov/find-a-housing-counselor/\)](https://www.consumerfinance.gov/find-a-housing-counselor/) at low or no cost to you.

Generally, applications for loss mitigation on a mortgage must be complete before your lender considers it. But in an emergency or disaster situation, completing this application might be difficult, so your lender should be able to offer you options anyway.

Your lender can also add a natural disaster code to your credit report, so that lenders understand why you had a missed or delayed payment.

[Review steps to take if your home is damaged or destroyed](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1521) (cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1521)

[Understand your options for when you can't make your mortgage payments](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/268) (cfpb.gov/askcfpb/268)

Managing rent payments

Generally, if you're able to continue living in your rental home, even if there is damage to it, you'll need to keep up with your rent payments. Be sure to review your lease to understand how a natural disaster or emergency affects your rental agreement with your landlord.

[See how renters can get help from FEMA disaster assistance](https://www.fema.gov/assistance/individual/sheltering-housing-options#rental)  (https://www.fema.gov/assistance/individual/sheltering-housing-options#rental)

In a situation where you could have trouble paying rent, contact your landlord right away. You might be able to work out a payment plan or arrangement that works for you both. State laws might apply to your situation.

Sometimes a disaster can mean parts of the home are unusable. In this event, you can contact your landlord to discuss reducing your rent. Notify your landlord in writing about damage to your unit and ask for an estimated timeframe for making the repairs.

Even if you're unable to live in your home—for example, if you can't access utilities like water, gas, or electricity—that doesn't necessarily end your lease. Generally, either you or the landlord must terminate the lease in writing. At that point, you can discuss having a portion of rent paid for that month and your security deposit returned. Your landlord can't use your security deposit to pay for damage caused by a natural disaster.

In general, landlords must provide their tenants with habitable premises. If you have trouble getting your landlord to make repairs or return your security deposit, talk to a lawyer or contact a housing services office in your state or local area.

Managing reverse mortgage payments

So that you have a record of your communications, notify your reverse mortgage lender or servicer about damage to your home by certified mail. Provide a way they can reach you by mail, phone, or e-mail. Staying in touch with your lender or servicer can help you understand what to do next, especially when it comes to avoiding foreclosure.

Sometimes a disaster can mean you cannot keep occupying the home as your primary residence or keep the home in good repair, as required by the terms of the reverse mortgage. Also, the disaster could get in the way of paying your property taxes and homeowner's insurance on time. Be sure to contact your reverse mortgage servicer and explain your situation.

Keeping up with your property taxes or charges could be a struggle in the aftermath of a disaster. Talk to your local tax authority to see if you can pay in installments, extend the deadline, or have late fees waived.

[Get our guide for reverse mortgage borrowers who are dealing with natural disasters](https://files.consumerfinance.gov/f/documents/cfpb_OA_natural_disaster_bifold.pdf)  (https://files.consumerfinance.gov/f/documents/cfpb_OA_natural_disaster_bifold.pdf)

Handling homeowner's insurance

Many people hire contractors soon after a disaster to begin repairs quickly on their home or business. Before you do, check with your insurance company and with your mortgage company or servicer about how and when the insurance money is distributed. Many mortgage agreements require insurance checks to be made out to both you and the mortgage company or servicer. This means your mortgage company could release portions of the money as repair work progresses, instead of releasing all the money at once.

Seek out reputable companies in your area to make repairs. Request a mechanic's lien waiver from your contractors at the beginning and for each phase of your project. A mechanic's lien waiver is a document saying the contractor has been paid in full and has no further rights to place a lien on your property to collect an unpaid bill.

[What happens after you file an insurance claim](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1523) (cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1523)

[How to find a trusted contractor to rebuild after a disaster](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1517) (cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1517)

Insurance might not pay for all the damage to your home. Your homeowner's insurance policy might cover actual cash value, which pays an amount based on the value of your home, rather than the total needed to restore it. Or, your policy might specify replacement cost, which covers the materials and labor to repair and rebuild. Flood damage is usually not covered by homeowner's insurance. For money to repair uninsured damage to a home, many homeowners need to borrow money. In a declared disaster area, to help cover uninsured costs, you can [apply to FEMA for disaster assistance or to the SBA for a disaster relief loan](https://www.disasterassistance.gov/)  (<https://www.disasterassistance.gov/>).

Look for affordable coverage down the road. After your home is damaged, you might run into more problems finding an insurance company to provide coverage. Your insurer might not renew your coverage. To contact the insurance companies that operate in your area, or to file a complaint, [look up your state's information through the National Association of Insurance Commissioners](https://content.naic.org/state-insurance-departments)  (<https://content.naic.org/state-insurance-departments>).

Even in areas where insurance companies have decided not to sell policies, most states and the District of Columbia provide insurance programs called Fair Access to Insurance Requirements (FAIR) plans, or a similar program. FAIR plans offer a basic level of protection from catastrophes, although the coverage typically costs more than a standard policy. [Contact the FAIR plan administrator in your state](https://www.iii.org/article/what-if-i-cant-get-coverage) [↗](https://www.iii.org/article/what-if-i-cant-get-coverage) (<https://www.iii.org/article/what-if-i-cant-get-coverage>).

Rising insurance costs might push your total housing payments too high for your budget. This could mean it's a good time to [talk to your mortgage servicer or a housing counselor about options for lower mortgage payments](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/268) (cfpb.gov/askcfpb/268).

[Check your specialty consumer report to be sure your insurance claim history is accurate](https://cfpb.gov/consumer-tools/credit-reports-and-scores/consumer-reporting-companies/companies-list/comprehensive-loss-underwriting-exchange/) (cfpb.gov/consumer-tools/credit-reports-and-scores/consumer-reporting-companies/companies-list/comprehensive-loss-underwriting-exchange/)

[How to take action when home insurance is canceled or costs surge](https://cfpb.gov/archive/newsroom/consumer-advisory-take-action-when-home-insurance-is-cancelled-or-costs-surge/) (cfpb.gov/archive/newsroom/consumer-advisory-take-action-when-home-insurance-is-cancelled-or-costs-surge/)

Closing on a home loan

If a disaster interrupts you in the process of buying a house, refinancing a mortgage, or taking out a loan based on your property, you and your lender might be able to be flexible with timelines and paperwork.

Appraisals and valuations. Generally, you receive appraisals and valuations of your property within three days before you close on a loan (or promptly after the appraisal is completed). In a disaster or emergency situation, you might agree to be more flexible about this requirement, as long as you receive the documents before the closing. This might make it quicker to close on a loan and give you access to the loaned money.

Loan Estimate and Closing Disclosure. Generally, when you are closing on a home loan, you receive a Loan Estimate and Closing Disclosure on a set schedule, determined by regulations. Usually you receive a Loan Estimate no later than seven days before closing, and a Closing Disclosure no later than three days before closing. But in the event of a bona fide personal financial emergency, your lender might agree to go ahead with the closing on a different timetable, so that you can close on the loan and receive the money ahead of the normal schedule. You still need to receive the documents, but you can decide to change the timing if it helps you with your emergency situation.

Deal with property damage

Emergency financial assistance could help pay for repairs to your home, car, or other property. Local assistance programs may be able to help you meet immediate relief needs. In a presidentially declared disaster area, federal resources could be available.

[More information about finding emergency assistance and relief programs \(cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1521\)](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1521)

Vehicle damage, payments, and insurance

When you discover damage to your vehicle, clarify with your insurance company and with your auto lender what type of insurance policy you have, what losses the insurance covers, and what you could owe.

Your insurance company compares the cost of repairs to the value of the car, and if the repairs are more expensive, the company can declare the vehicle a total loss and pay you the fair market value of the vehicle on the date of the damage. Then, compare the amount you owe on your auto loan to the insurance paid on your totaled car—you might owe the difference to the lender. [If you've purchased a guaranteed asset protection \(GAP\) product \(cfpb.gov/askcfpb/797\)](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/797), you should check to see if it covers the difference.

[Understand your options for when you can't make your auto loan payments \(cfpb.gov/askcfpb/849\)](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/849)

Renter's insurance

Renter's insurance covers your belongings if they are damaged inside a home you rent. Your landlord is not responsible for damage to your personal property inside the housing unit. Review your policy to make sure you understand what property is covered, and whether you can file a claim for the situation you are in. Sometimes renter's insurance covers the cost of living somewhere else if you can't live in your home. Check your policy to see if it includes this option.

Manage your bills

As you talk with companies about the issues below, be sure to write down who you talked to and when.

Utility bills

If you had to leave your home or if your utilities and services are not working, companies might have a hard time reaching you. They could send overdue bills and debts to a collection agency. Set up a forwarding address and update your information, so they can contact you before problems arise.

Credit cards and other bills

Review your income and savings and determine how much money you have available to pay bills and debts. If you can't make your credit card payments, [contact the company](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1697) (cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1697) to see if they can offer more affordable repayment options.

For student loans, including Direct Loans from the federal Department of Education, many lenders can provide disaster forbearance. Contact your loan servicer.

Your lenders might be willing to work with you, but be proactive to avoid extra expenses, fees, and actions that could negatively impact your credit score. Ask the companies to note a disaster code in your credit file, so that future lenders understand your situation.

[Review other steps to take if you can't pay your credit card bills](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1513) (cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1513) after a disaster or emergency.

Automatic payments

After a disaster, electrical blackouts and flooding can make it hard to send payments on time or to stop automatic payments. This can lead to overdraft fees. Contact your bank, financial institution, or lenders quickly [if you need to stop automatic payments](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/2023) (cfpb.gov/askcfpb/2023) or if you will miss a payment because of the disaster. Explain the situation and ask for a waiver of any late fees.

Keep an eye on your credit

After a natural disaster or emergency, you may find yourself facing unexpected issues with your credit reports or scores.

For example, arrangements you make with lenders or credit card companies to make your payments more affordable may not be listed accurately on your credit report. If the company was also affected by the event, it may have trouble with its own records and reports.

[You can get a free credit report from each of the three nationwide credit reporting companies at least once every 12 months](https://files.consumerfinance.gov/f/documents/cfpb_adult-fin-ed_check-your-credit-report.pdf)  (https://files.consumerfinance.gov/f/documents/cfpb_adult-fin-ed_check-your-credit-report.pdf). Until the end of 2026, you can get an additional six free credit reports every 12 months from Equifax. When you visit the site, you can follow the steps to view reports online, updated weekly. This means that you have opportunities to request reports, monitor your credit, and ask for any errors to be corrected. You can request a copy of your credit reports through [AnnualCreditReport.com](https://www.annualcreditreport.com/requestReport/landingPage.action)  (https://www.annualcreditreport.com/requestReport/landingPage.action).

You also have the right to request reports from other specialty consumer reporting companies. As you recover from the emergency, you might find issues with your tenant screening reports, bank or checking accounts, or personal property insurance reports. [See our list of specialty reporting companies](https://files.consumerfinance.gov/f/documents/cfpb_consumer-reporting-companies-list.pdf)  (https://files.consumerfinance.gov/f/documents/cfpb_consumer-reporting-companies-list.pdf).

Scams increase during natural disaster recovery

While many people pull together during times of crisis, there is also an increased risk for scams and fraud. [To avoid scams after a natural disaster or emergency \(cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1529\)](https://cfpb.gov/askcfpb/1529), you need to ask questions to help you determine if something is too good to be true.

Red flags to watch out for:

People who want you to pay up-front fees to help you claim services, benefits, or get loans.

Contractors selling repairs door-to-door, especially when they ask to receive payment up front or offer deep discounts.

Con artists with fake credentials or uniforms, posing as government employees, insurance adjusters, law enforcement officials, or bank employees. Do not give out personal information to people you don't know. Government employees do not charge to help you get a benefit or service and do not ask for payment or financial information.

People pressuring you with limited-time offers, trying to get you to decide on the spot or to sign something without enough time to review it. Take your time reading and understanding anything presented to you. And ask a trusted friend, relative, or attorney before acting.

Sellers who can't or won't answer your questions are a sign you might want to look for someone else to do business with.

Here are steps you can take to recover from losses because of a scam or fraud:

- **Contact your state's Attorney General:** [Your state attorney general](https://www.naag.org/fi-nd-my-ag/) [↗](https://www.naag.org/fi-nd-my-ag/) (<https://www.naag.org/fi-nd-my-ag/>) might be able to take action.
- **Submit a fraud report to the FTC:** Although the FTC cannot resolve your problem, when you [submit a fraud report](https://reportfraud.ftc.gov/) [↗](https://reportfraud.ftc.gov/) (<https://reportfraud.ftc.gov/>), it is shared with more than 2,800 law enforcers, and reports are used to investigate and bring cases against fraud, scams, and bad business practices.

You can submit a complaint to the CFPB for problems with financial products or services like your mortgage, credit card, money transfers, debt collection, or credit reporting. You can [submit a complaint](https://youtu.be/bh3nejWtSjA) [↗](https://youtu.be/bh3nejWtSjA) (<https://youtu.be/bh3nejWtSjA>) to us [online](https://cfpb.gov/complaint/) (cfpb.gov/complaint/) or by calling [\(855\) 411-CFPB \(2372\)](https://www.fcc.gov/000411).